I was still fuming. ‘Yes, it is your job to stall development of a liquid propulsion engine. And your job is much easier than mine.’ I stormed out of the meeting.

I was reminded of this spat while seated at RCD where the French disagreed with each other with extreme civility and professionalism. But then, SEP was not ISRO. At ISRO, often people with no hands-on knowledge in propulsion systems and development are put on quality control. Often, like the planning and programme group, it was considered a dump yard for the bosses to send underperformers. Here at SEP, quality control has always been headed by a person who had got his hands dirty on the work floor. Our structural engineer H R S Mani, an IITian from Bangalore, imbibed these lessons in quality control from SEP and helped ISRO adopt it in a professional way.

Earlier, my scant respect for the ISRO quality control teams coupled with my impatience to deliver made me take several impromptu decisions based on my hunch feeling. Let me confess that sometimes this was in contravention to protocol. One such decision came with sufficient risk. And here is one of the best kept secrets.

After the untimely and shocking death of Vikram Sarabhai on 30 December 1971, Satish Dhawan was to take over as ISRO chairman. But at the time of Sarabhai’s death, Dhawan was midway through a programme in the US, and the government appointed M G K Menon as a short-term chairman. Menon, a physicist mentored by Homi J Bhabha at the Tata Institute of Fundamental Research, was then the electronics commission chairman.

ISRO had developed the Rohini-560 rocket, and Sarabhai had appointed me the chief of Rocket Assembly and Test Facility (RATF), which was part of the Space Science & Technology Centre (SSTC) in Trivandrum. Soon after taking over as the chairman, Menon wanted to witness a static test firing of the Rohini rocket. Arrangements for the test were on at a great pace and I, as the RATF chief, was overseeing them. It was the new chairman’s first visit to the centre and we were eager to demonstrate our readiness.